Siby Mathews, Joshua and Vijayan wrote separate letters to the Chief Minister seeking withdrawal of the consent given to the CBI to investigate the case. It was ridiculous to do that since the agency had already filed its report and a court had discharged the accused, but derision is often the child of desperation.

While the letters of Joshua and Vijayan were routed through the DGP, Siby Mathews showed the temerity to write directly to the Chief Minister. The Chief Minister's office forwarded this letter to the DGP, who recommended that the government may implead in Vijayan's petition for a review of the CBI's final report. 'There is scope for a thorough reinvestigation of the ISRO espionage case,' said the DGP's confidential note to the government.

Now Siby Mathews and others went to the Chief Minister and fell at his feet. I am told, they painted a picture of themselves as valiant sleuths who tried their best to protect national interest, but ended up being wronged. Their plea: a re-investigation. With the DGP, too, suggesting there was scope for such a move, Nayanar agreed.

The CBI sent its confidential report detailing the unprofessionalism of the police officers and seeking action against them on 9 June 1996. The next day the state government issued an executive order for re-investigation. It formed a special team headed by T P Senkumar, commissioner of police, Ernakulam. The team members were M Sugathan, DSP, CBCID, Thiruvananthapuram (earlier Trivandrum), T V Sasikumar, assistant commissioner of police (traffic), Thiruvananthapuram and V K Girijathan Nair, circle inspector of police, Vizhinjam, Thiruvananthapuram. C A Chaly, additional director general of police (crime) was to 'personally supervise' the investigation.

The same month, the government appointed M K Damodaran, who represented Nayanar in the case when he was served a notice as the chief editor of CPI (M) organ *Deshabhimani*, which was reporting the spy case. Kallada Sukumaran, who represented Achuthanandan while seeking a judicial inquiry into the case, was appointed the new director general of